

Self-Editing Checklist

The three-pass method from the course, in printable form. One pass at a time.

Order matters. Fix structure before scenes, and scenes before sentences. There is no point polishing a line that a later structural cut will delete. Big to small, always.

01 Structural pass Read the whole draft fast, take notes, touch nothing until the read is done.

- ☐ The premise still matches the book I actually wrote. Drafts drift. Update the sentence or the book.
- ☐ Every beat lands near its target percentage. A midpoint at 70% is a second act dragging its feet.
- ☐ The protagonist causes the climax. Not luck, not a rescuer, not coincidence.
- ☐ Each subplot pays off or gets cut. A thread with no knot is a loose end the reader trips on.
- ☐ The midpoint truly flips the story's direction. If you could remove it and nothing changes, it is not a midpoint.
- ☐ Stakes escalate act over act. Chapter twenty must cost more than chapter two.
- ☐ The ending answers the question chapter one planted. The contract closes where it opened.

02 Scene pass One scene at a time. Audition every scene for its place in the book.

- ☐ Every scene has someone who wants something. No want, no scene.
- ☐ Every scene flips a value. Minus to plus or plus to minus. Same state in and out means cut or rebuild.
- ☐ Scenes enter late and leave early. Trim the hellos and the goodbyes.
- ☐ The conflict is on the page, not implied. Readers cannot feel friction that happens offstage.
- ☐ Point of view holds steady within each scene. Head-hopping spends trust you will want later.
- ☐ Information-only scenes are cut or given conflict. Exposition must fight for its ride.

03 Line pass Only now. Sentence by sentence, with the structure already sound.

- ☐ Filter words removed. Saw, felt, noticed, realized: they hold the reader at arm's length.
- ☐ Every adverb put on trial. Most confess to a weak verb underneath.
- ☐ Passive voice converted where the actor matters. "She broke it" beats "it was broken".
- ☐ Dialogue tags are mostly "said". It disappears. "Expostulated" does not.
- ☐ Pet words hunted with a search. Everyone has three. Find yours, thin them out.
- ☐ Sentence lengths vary. Read a page aloud. Monotony is audible before it is visible.
- ☐ Cliches replaced with something you actually saw. A borrowed image is a skipped image.
- ☐ First and last sentence of every chapter checked twice. They carry more weight than any others.